# what is the current population of karachi in 2025, and what are the most reliable sources?

Karachi's metro area population in 2025 is best described as being in the high-teens to low-twenties millions, with the most defensible point estimate around 20–21 million depending on whether you use official census-based projections or independent aggregators. Different sources use different geographic boundaries and methods, so there is no single universally agreed figure. [1] [2] [3]

## Key 2025 Population Estimates

- Macrotrends (metro area series) states: "The current metro area population of Karachi in 2025 is 18,077,000, a 2.43% increase from 2024." [4]
- StatisticsTimes (UN-based city projections) lists Karachi's 2025 population as 21,422,590, rising to 21,857,801 in 2026. [1]
- The Commissioner Karachi website cites the 2023 census with a figure "around 20.3 million," which is a useful anchor for 2025 estimates once modest growth is assumed. [2]

Because these figures refer to slightly different geographic definitions (city proper vs. metro) and methodologies (census vs. projections), most analysts would quote a range rather than a single "true" number, e.g. 18–21 million, with official census-derived sources suggesting just above 20 million. [3] [4] [2] [1]

## Why Numbers Differ

- Geographic scope: Some datasets use "city proper," others "urban agglomeration," and others "metro area," which can add or omit surrounding districts. [4] [3] [1]
- Data basis:
  - Official Pakistani sources rely on national censuses (1998, 2017, 2023) and administrative updates. [2] [3]
  - International or private aggregators (Macrotrends, StatisticsTimes, WorldPopulationReview) extrapolate from those censuses using their own growth models. [3] [4] [1]
- Timing and revisions: The 2023 census results are still being digested and sometimes revised, so different sites may be using slightly different baseline numbers or older estimates. [2] [3]

This combination of factors explains why you see figures ranging from about 18 million up past 21 million for "Karachi 2025." [4] [1] [3] [2]

### Most Reliable Source Types

For a consultant or researcher, you'd usually treat these as tiered in reliability:

#### 1. Official Pakistani Government Sources

- Pakistan Bureau of Statistics (PBS) publications and census tables are the primary authority for city populations. [3] [2]
- Government or commissioner websites (like Commissioner Karachi's census page) that summarize the latest official census figures are the closest to "official" population statements for Karachi. [2]

These are the best sources when you need a number that will stand up in formal reports, government work, or policy analysis. [3] [2]

#### 2. CityPopulation.de, UN Data, and Derived Platforms

- WorldPopulationReview explicitly cites CityPopulation and official Pakistan census series as its underlying data, and shows Karachi's 2026 figure (21,243,390) with explanation of methodology, which you can back-calculate to 2025. [3]
- StatisticsTimes uses UN and related projections for "population of cities in Pakistan," giving year-by-year city populations including Karachi. [1]

These are generally reliable for comparative and trend work, provided you note that they are projections built from official censuses. [1] [3]

#### 3. Other Aggregator Sites

- Macrotrends provides clean time series charts and tables and is widely used, but it is still a secondary aggregator and can differ from other projection sets; its 18,077,000 figure is noticeably lower than UN-style projections. [4] [1] [3]
- Chislennost.com and Aznations.com list much smaller figures (around 11–15 million for 2025), which likely reflect narrower city boundaries or outdated baselines and so are less suitable for serious work on Karachi's true urban scale. [5] [6]

These can be useful as cross-checks, but you would not treat them as top-tier references for policy, investment, or academic work. [6] [5] [4] [1] [3]

### Practical Recommendation for Your Use Case

If you are preparing a consulting report:

- Use a census-anchored figure and clearly cite the source, e.g. "Karachi's population based on Pakistan's 2023 census is around 20.3 million; with recent growth, 2025 estimates place the city in the 20–21 million range." [1] [2] [3]
- Prefer Pakistan Bureau of Statistics or official commissioner/census publications, supplemented by CityPopulation/UN-based platforms (StatisticsTimes, WorldPopulationReview) for year-by-year projections and international comparability. [2] [1] [3]

If you tell me the exact context (e.g., urban planning, consumer market sizing, infrastructure demand), I can recommend which of these specific numbers and definitions (city vs. metro) are most appropriate for your analysis.

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# I need this data for urban planning projects to assess infrastructure needs

For urban planning and infrastructure assessment, you should use Karachi's 2023 census as your baseline (about 20.3 million residents) and then apply official or UN-style growth projections to reach a working 2025 figure in the 20–21 million range, clearly stating whether you mean the metropolitan area or city proper. This will give you a defensible, policy-grade population figure for demand forecasting while staying consistent with official data. [11] [12] [13]

### Which Population Figure to Use

- The Commissioner Karachi census page reports Karachi's population at roughly 20.3 million based on Pakistan's 2023 census, which is your most authoritative anchor for any planning work. [12]
- UN/CityPopulation-derived projections (e.g., StatisticsTimes, WorldPopulationReview) extend this forward year by year and place Karachi in the low-21 million range by 2026; this implies a 2025 figure around 20.8–21.0 million if you assume steady growth. [13] [11]
- For infrastructure planning, it is common practice to:
  - Take the latest official census value (20.3 million in 2023). [12]
  - Apply an annual growth rate from UN or national planning documents (about 2–3% per year for Karachi). [11] [13]
  - Use the resulting 2025 estimate as your "design year" population, clearly labeled as a projection.

If you need, I can help you build a simple growth-projection table (e.g., 2023–2035) tailored to your specific project horizon.

### Why Official Census + Projections Work Best for Planning

- Urban and regional planning guidelines emphasize that population size, growth rate, age structure, and migration patterns are fundamental inputs for forecasting infrastructure needs (water, transport, housing, health, etc.). [14]
- For decisions on capital-intensive systems (mass transit, trunk water and sewer lines, power distribution), public authorities and lenders expect numbers tied back to the national census or official statistical agency, not just private aggregators. [14] [12]
- Using census-based projections lets you:
  - Align with national and provincial development plans (e.g., Pakistan's planning documents).

- Create consistent scenarios (low/medium/high growth) for stress-testing infrastructure capacity.
- Update easily when new census or survey data becomes available.

Macrotrends and other aggregators can be useful for quick checks or comparative charts, but in urban planning reports you should reference PBS/official census plus UN-style projections as your primary population source. [15] [13] [11] [12]

### How to Link Population to Infrastructure Needs

When you translate Karachi's 20–21 million residents into infrastructure requirements, planners usually work through a set of standard data categories. [16] [17] [14]

### Core demand drivers

- Demographic data: Total population, growth rate, household size, age distribution, and spatial distribution across districts drive demand for schools, clinics, transit routes, and utilities. [16] [14]
- Land use and density: Residential, commercial, and industrial land use patterns, plus built-up vs. vacant land, tell you where infrastructure must be expanded or reinforced. [14] [16]
- Economic and mobility patterns: Employment clusters, commuting flows, and traffic congestion data are used to size and align road networks, BRT/metro lines, and freight corridors. [18] [14]

### Sector-specific examples (using your 2025 population)

For a working 2025 Karachi population of about 20–21 million:

- Water supply and sanitation:
  - Multiply population by per-capita daily demand (e.g., 100–150 liters per person per day, adjusted to local benchmarks) to get required system capacity, then compare to existing plant output and network losses. [18] [14]
  - Map underserved high-density areas to prioritize trunk mains, pumping stations, and sewer upgrades.
- Transport:
  - Use population plus trip rates (average trips per person per day) to estimate peak-hour loads, then distribute by mode (cars, buses, paratransit, rail). [19] [14]
  - GIS tools and aerial imagery (e.g., Nearmap-style solutions) help visualize congestion corridors and test scenarios such as new BRT lines or grade-separated interchanges. [19] [18]
- Housing and social services:
  - Household counts and average household size allow you to project housing unit needs; overlay informal settlements and vacancy to plan infill, regularization, or greenfield expansion. [16] [14]

- Population-to-facility ratios (beds per 1,000 people, classrooms per student, etc.) show where to add hospitals, schools, and emergency services.[14] [16]

In each case, the total and spatial distribution of population is the starting point, and you then layer sector-specific demand norms and service standards.

### Recommended Data Stack for Karachi Projects

For robust urban planning and infrastructure analysis in Karachi, you can build your data stack around:

- Population and demographics
    - Pakistan Bureau of Statistics census tables for 2023 (city and district level).[12]
    - UN/CityPopulation-style projections for annual growth to 2025 and beyond (via StatisticsTimes, WorldPopulationReview).[13] [11]
- Spatial and land use data
    - Official land use plans and zoning maps from Karachi's local government or planning authorities.
    - Remote sensing and aerial imagery platforms (Nearmap-type services or similar) to detect land-use changes, construction trends, and informal expansion.[18] [19]
- Sectoral infrastructure and service data
    - Utility providers (water, power, gas, telecom) for network maps and capacity data.
    - Transport agencies for traffic counts, transit ridership, and road condition data.[19] [18]
    - Health, education, and housing agencies for facility inventories and performance indicators.[16] [14]

Data toolkits from organizations like Cities Alliance highlight how integrating demographic, land use, infrastructure, and service data within GIS or dashboards gives city managers a clearer picture of priorities and investment sequencing.[20] [16]

If you share the specific infrastructure sectors you're focusing on (e.g., water, transport, solid waste), I can help you turn the 20–21 million 2025 population into concrete planning ratios and capacity targets for Karachi.

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1. https://statisticstimes.com/demographics/country/pakistan-cities-population.php
2. https://commissionerkarachi.gos.pk/population
3. https://worldpopulationreview.com/cities/pakistan/karachi
4. https://www.macrotrends.net/global-metrics/cities/22044/karachi/population
5. https://chislennost.com/en/pk/population_of_karachi_1839.html
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15. https://www.macrotrends.net/global-metrics/cities/22044/karachi/population
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